group from any process designed to forge peace between India and Pakistan. The issue of Kashmir, over which India and Pakistan have fought three wars, is not the only stumbling block to peace or to dealing with Lashkar. But it does play a major part in Pakistan's calculus. The predominant view appears to be that dismantling Lashkar without extracting some concessions from India would remove a valuable, and one of the few, sources of leverage Pakistan has at its disposal. Irrespective of what one feels about the use of terrorism as a bargaining chip, it is unrealistic to assume support for Lashkar will cease without a political payoff in return.

The group understands its utility too. One member very close to the leadership asserted that 'the ISI cannot stop its support because Lashkar has the ability to inflict the biggest losses on India.' Thus, it will not be dismantled so long as the Pakistani security establishment needs leverage against the country's rival.[5] It is not at all certain that Lashkar could be stopped from launching an attack to upset relations with India should they begin to improve. Complicating the situation is the fact that spoilers exist in both countries. Lashkar remains among the best instruments to sabotage any burgeoning peace process, and particularly one that hardliners in Pakistan believe gives away too much to India. This geopolitical reality suggests the group will remain intact for the foreseeable future. So too does Pakistan's domestic political reality, where the army and ISI wield disproportionate power. In addition to Lashkar's strategic value and the possibility of a backlash that could result from attempting to dismantle it, the group's members have forged relationships with personnel in these institutions. A number of former officers joined its ranks, which further strengthens these bonds. Because Lashkar and the army both recruit heavily from Punjab, familial and friendship ties compound and complicate matters. Lashkar's provision of social services and relief aid has also enabled it to forge relationships with people in the national as well as provincial governments. As a result, sympathizers exist in the army and ISI, as well as among the police and officials in the national and provincial bureaucracies, albeit to a lesser extent. Further, JuD has developed into a formidable political-religious force. Even those officials who may not sympathize with the group nevertheless fear its political clout, with some politicians depending on it to deliver needed vote banks. All of these